Throughout the summer of 1960, Nikita Khrushchev and the Soviet propaganda machine followed Robert Kennedy's advice, doing nothing to voice support for John Kennedy. Khrushchev lambasted the Eisenhower administration instead, suggesting that the missile gap Kennedy was talking about really existed. In September 1960, in the middle of the presidential campaign, Khrushchev popped up in the United States to speak at the UN General Assembly. Going on the attack as always, he asked: "Do you want to make us turn the arms race into a competition? We do not want that, but we are not afraid of it. We will beat you! Our missile production is on a conveyor belt." If any American thought that Kennedy was mistaken in speaking of a missile gap, there was the leader of the Soviet state himself confirming the words of the junior senator from Massachusetts.[3] The missile gap rhetoric helped Kennedy win the presidential race.

At 10:00 a.m. on December 1, 1960, less than a month after Kennedy's election, the KGB agent Yurii Barsukov once again knocked on the door of Robert Kennedy's office. "Mr. B, *Izvestiia* Daily, coming in," read Robert's calendar that day. In his report on the meeting, which went all the way to Khrushchev, Barsukov noted that Robert was ready to speak on behalf of his brother, not just himself. "Kennedy expects," read the report, "to sign a nuclear test-ban treaty as early as 1961 if both sides take a number of steps to accommodate each other." Robert Kennedy also assured the Kremlin emissary that the president "would do all he could to reach agreement on the Berlin problem." Kennedy ended the meeting by hinting at the possibility of American-Soviet cooperation with regard to common concerns about China, telling Barsukov that "in the next few years the fundamental problem would not be Soviet-American relations but Washington's relations with China."[4]

Khrushchev could not fail to be pleased by what he read in Barsukov's report. On January 21, 1961, the day after Kennedy's inauguration, he ordered the publication of the young president's inaugural address in the Soviet media. He also did something that he had refused to do for Eisenhower, releasing two American pilots then in Soviet custody. Captains Freeman Bruce Olmstead and John McCone had been piloting an RB-47H Stratojet full of electronic surveillance equipment off the Kola Peninsula in the Barents Sea when they were shot down by a Soviet MiG-19 (NATO